



MONEY & TOOLS

The Lean AI Tool Stack

What to actually pay for in 2026 — and the expensive tools you can skip.

Spend where it compounds

Your AI dollars should go to the tools you touch every day — not the shiny ones you used once. Here's how to decide.

Pay for

- One strong general model (your daily driver)
- A scheduler for distribution
- One voice/clip tool if you publish video
- Cheap hosting + domains

Think twice

- Multiple overlapping video generators — pick one
- Avatar tools if you film yourself
- All-in-one platforms you don't fully use
- 'Autonomous agent' tools that duplicate your main model

THE SELF-SHOT RULE

If your brand is real, on-camera you, you need far fewer paid media tools than a faceless creator. Authenticity is cheaper AND converts better.

Right-size, don't just cut

Some tools you need only during production sprints. Subscribe the month you use them, pause the months you don't.



GO DEEPER

Want this done for you?

This guide hands you the system. If you'd rather have it built for you, that's what I do: I find where your time leaks and build the tool that plugs it. No hype — just your hours, back.

LET'S TALK

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Built something with this guide? Send it. I love seeing it.